

ity long before the crisis forced the transition.

Closer home at Infosys, the board is maintaining a calibrated approach. They aim to ensure continuity amid industry disruption while giving the board time to execute a smoother, more deliberate leadership transition, rather than facing an abrupt churn.

At the Tata Group, the turbulence surrounding Cyrus Mistry's abrupt exit exposed how leadership transitions can quickly turn into governance flash-points, despite strong institutional structures. The group later moved towards a more formalised succession approach under Chairman N. Chandrasekaran, reflecting how even highly respected organisations are forced to rethink continuity after disruption.

A recent CEO & Board Confidence Monitor by a global executive search and consulting firm, Heidrick & Struggles, highlights this disconnect clearly. While more than two-thirds of leaders express strong confidence in their executive teams' ability to deliver on the strategic plan, that confidence drops sharply when it comes to long-term continuity. Only four in ten respondents believe their CEO succession planning adequately positions the organisation for the future.

82 | A 2025 Talent Readiness Study by Deloitte India offers a slightly more optimistic view on structure, but not necessarily on outcomes. It finds that 78% of organisations in India have institutionalised succession planning frameworks for leadership roles, with 50% of CXO positions filled through internal talent. At the same time, the study highlights a parallel shift in family businesses, where 57% of the next generation enters between ages 24-27, 60% hold postgraduate degrees, and 59% of spouses are actively involved in the business ecosystem.

The signal is clear: succession is more formalised than ever, but 'ready-now' leadership remains elusive.

MATURE FRAMEWORKS

The gap rarely lies in frameworks, but in how they translate into reality.

"On paper, most mature organisations have robust succession grids, talent reviews, and identified successors. But when a real transition moment arrives, three cracks typically show up," says Sumit Mitra, CEO, Tesco Business Solutions, the global business services division of British multinational retailer Tesco.

First, readiness is often overstated. Many successors are "ready in 12-24 months," not "ready tomorrow." "The capability may exist, but contextual exposure, running a P&L, handling board pressure, leading through ambiguity is often missing," he explains.

Second, breadth of experience is too narrow. Lead-

AN IDEAL FUTURE-READY SUCCESSION

SHIFT FROM ROLES TO CAPABILITIES: Focus moves from replacing positions to building skills the business will need tomorrow.

SELECT FOR AGILITY, NOT TENURE: Learning agility, curiosity, and ability to lead through ambiguity outweigh experience alone.

BUILD PORTABLE LEADERSHIP CAPABILITIES: Commercial judgment, data fluency, customer focus, and ability to integrate tech with business.

CREATE REAL-WORLD EXPOSURE EARLY: Leaders are tested in live transformation roles, AI deployments, and cross-functional assignments.

MOVE TO ALWAYS-ON TALENT MAPPING: Continuous tracking of performance, adaptability, and impact replaces static annual plans.

DESIGN FOR OPTIONALITY, NOT CERTAINTY: Build leaders who can step into multiple, undefined future roles.

EMBED AI INTO MAINSTREAM LEADERSHIP: AI won't sit in isolated roles; it becomes a core leadership capability.

INSTITUTIONALISE DEVELOPMENT, NOT INTENT: Mandatory role rotations and early successor identification with measurable plans.

REWARD LEADERS WHO BUILD SUCCESSORS: Systems must incentivise creating replacements, not penalise it.

ers are still developed within silos, without enough cross-functional or enterprise-wide exposure. "In today's environment, the ability to connect technology, customer, and commercial outcomes is critical, and this is where many pipelines fall short," he adds.

Mitra also points to a cultural challenge. "In many organisations, there is still an over-reliance on trust and familiarity. Leaders often default to those they know well, which can limit bench strength and delay the development of newer, diverse leaders."